Atyanta-abhava (unlimited absence): understood as holding in past, present and future, this means impossibilities both logical and physical, for example, the son of a barren woman and the hare's horn.

Anyonya-abhava (mutual absence) is difference: the denial of identity between two things such as the pot and the cloth and the assertions that fire differs from water and the table is not the pot. This need not involve perception.

See ***anupalabdhi-pramana***

Further reading: G. Bhattacharya 1989; Ingalls 1951; Kajiyama 1998; Matilal 1968

Abhidharma: a style of literary composition and analytical method, practised by some early Buddhist schools, *Abhidharma* is the systematisation of Buddhist ideas that were presented discursively in the Buddha's sermons, in the Pali Canon. These texts, compiled between 100 BCE and 400 CE by various Buddhist schools, are exhaustive catalogues of the mental and material atoms (***dharma***) that are the building blocks of all persons, experiences and objects. Although each ***dharma*** is said to be independent of all others and self-sufficient, the increasingly complex *Abhidharma* catalogues classify them so that they appear interdependent.

It is a fundamental Buddhist principle that nothing compounded, conditioned, or consisting of parts is ultimately real. The human mind conventionally interprets a combination of parts as a single entity with an enduring nature because this outlook suits our needs. The *Abhidharmikas* held that the atoms are ultimately real entities (***paramartha-sat***/*dravya-sat*). They thought that the *dharmas*' possession of intrinsic natures or essences (***svabhava***) distinguished them from the compound entities that they make up. Essence here means a nature that